

MacBook Pro – What is the “something really great” we should wait for?

Welcoming 2013

The critical bit – just two words – Jonathan Ive. He is the person responsible for what the iPhone, the iPods, the iPad and the MacBooks have looked like, for quite a few years now. His bio on Apple’s website reads, “In 2003, he was named Designer of the Year by the Design Museum London and awarded the title Royal Designer for Industry by The Royal Society of Arts.” Why we are talking about Jonathan Ive, Senior Vice President, Industrial Design is because he now has taken charge of the software side of things as well. The next version of the desktop and the mobile operating systems will surely bear the hallmark of the man who takes great pains in ensuring that the final offering is visually appealing. It is safe to say that iOS 7 and Mac OS X 10.9 might be significantly different from their current avatars.

Apple’s thinking is straightforward – Jony Ive has been doing a fairly remarkable job churning out one good-looking device after the other. With Forstall’s departure, it only makes sense that the person making the amazing hardware should have a say in how the next versions of the iOS and the OS X look. The feature set will be dictated by various

factors, but when it comes down to the crux of it, presentation will be key. The current look of the OS X has been relatively similar (Porsche-style?) over the last couple of iterations. A major change may not be warranted, but some streamlining and tweaks are necessary. For example,

Launchpad is still not an integral part of the entire experience of using a MacBook. It is all well and good to bring the OS closer, at least visually, but better deployment is needed.

SIRI on the Mac

Dictation and Speech are already a part of OS X Mountain Lion, and it would only be logical for SIRI to arrive next, since this is the expansion of the already prevalent feature. It is a server-based application, and deploying it on another platform will not involve too many complications. While this will excite a lot of Mac users globally, we don’t think it makes any sense for Indian buyers, primarily because SIRI refuses to understand our accent, and also because it isn’t fun screaming at your laptop to get it to undo things that you didn’t ask it to do in the first place!

Maps

Sources seem pretty certain that the Maps will also arrive on the desktop platform in 2013. There will be two ways of doing it – a dedicated Maps app with OS X that will allow access to third party apps as well, and a browser based service much like Google and Bing maps. However, what Apple needs to do (and surely they will admit this internally within the organization) is sort out the maps mess they have managed to create. The current embarrassment cannot continue, and a complete overhaul needs to be done. Expect important announcements in the first quarter of 2013. What will not see a major change is the overall look and feel of the operating system. Yes, there will be tweaks to make it look better and possibly more functional, but the Jony Ive effect

will probably be more visible on the iOS than on the OS X, at least in the next update.

Don't forget the hardware!

Talk about what to expect from Apple in 2013, and not talk about the hardware is just wrong! And we would not let you go through that incomplete journey. Here is what we think will happen on the hardware front with the Macs.

Retina Display

First up, the Retina display. This arrived on the MacBook Pro in the latest refresh, and now it is the turn of the MacBook Air. It will be interesting to see if Apple retains the dual range of the MacBook Air – one with the Retina display and one without. This is currently happening with the MacBook Pro range. Pricing will see the new 11-inch and 13-inch non-Retina Air versions to be priced similar to the current prices, with the Retina versions getting the “top of the line” tag.

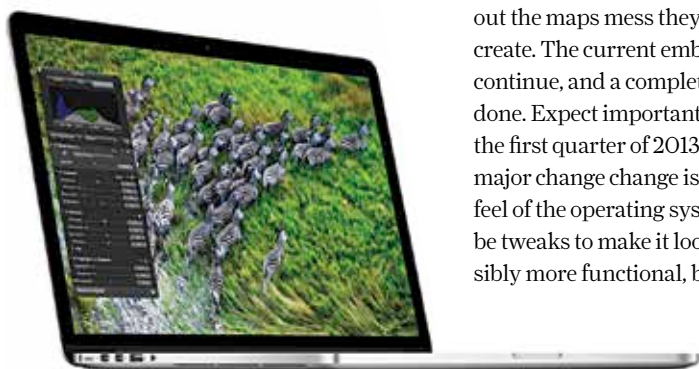
Thinner MacBooks

What is pretty much confirmed is that the next edition of the Air and the Pro will be even thinner than the current one. If you thought that was not possible, particularly in the case of the Air, think again. Apple is working on tweaking the keyboard backlighting to get the desired effect. According to some reports, a thinner set of LEDs is to be deployed. Others suggest that Apple will reduce the amount of backlighting to get the current thickness of 0.40mm down to 0.25mm on the new Air.

Intel Haswell

Intel’s Haswell processors will also make their way into the next generation of MacBooks. While the new range retains the 22nm process seen with the current Ivy Bridge range, a newer architecture will mean better performance. According to the recent leaks, the Haswell range has only one dual core Core i5 processor, while the other entire Core i5 and Core i7 range is quad core. Coupled with more RAM and an SSD in some models, performance will be rather delightful.

Tim Cook had said back in June 2012 that “something really great” is coming for Pro users in 2013. Our ears still ring with those words, as we wait in anticipation and expectation. For the rest of the range, we expect similar great stuff. 



The Retina Display will be heading to the MacBook Air in 2013